Writing a short story or anecdote

Objective: To write a short, well-organised story or anecdote using narrative tenses, time sequencers and vivid language that shows feelings.

The idea in two lines: A story moves from a setting to a problem, a climax and an ending. An anecdote is a short, often funny, true-sounding story that ends with a surprise or a punchline.

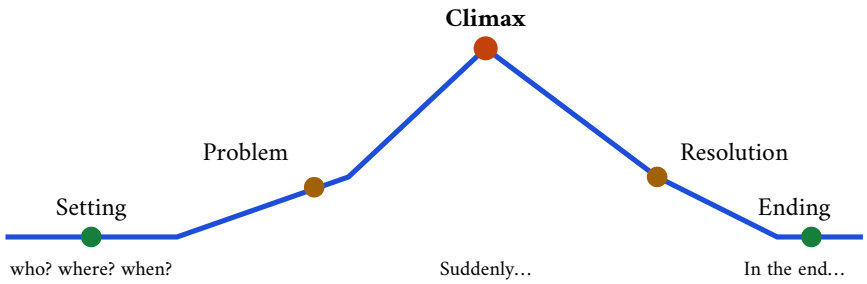


Figure 1: The story arc: tension rises from the setting to the climax, then falls to the ending.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Structure:** opening (characters, place, time), problem, climax, resolution, ending or moral. An anecdote may end with a **punchline**.
2. **Past simple** for the main events in order: *He opened the door and screamed.*
3. **Past continuous** for background actions: *It was raining and people were rushing home.*
4. **Past perfect** for an earlier past action: *When I arrived, the bus had already left.*
5. **Sequencers:** first, then, after that, suddenly, as soon as, while, finally, in the end.
6. **Vivid language:** feeling adjectives (terrified, relieved), strong verbs (rushed, whispered) and direct speech in inverted commas.
7. Usually written in the **first or third person**, with a short title and paragraphs for each stage.

🟢 Examples

1. Combine with *while*: I was reading. The lights went out. → *While I was reading, the lights went out.* **Explanation:** long background action + short interrupting action.
2. Put the verb in the right tense: When we reached the station, the train (leave). **Answer:** had left (earlier action).
3. Model anecdote opening: *Last summer, my uncle was fishing quietly when, suddenly, his line pulled hard. He was sure he had caught a huge fish…* **Explanation:** setting, background, then a surprise.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Mixing present and past tenses in the same story.
- Using the past simple for an earlier action instead of the **past perfect**.
- Writing one long paragraph with no clear climax or ending.
- Repeating *and then* instead of varying sequencers.

🟡 Quick review

- Setting → problem → climax → resolution → ending.
- Past simple = events; past continuous = background.
- Past perfect = the earlier of two past actions.
- Vary sequencers and show feelings.
- Anecdote = short story + surprise or punchline.

madrasadz.com